

John Flower: Topographical Studies in Leicester and Leicestershire

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Leicester artist John Flower (1793-1861) is best known for his depictions of Leicester street scenes and local buildings which appeared in the volume of 25 lithographs published in 1826. (1) These now familiar images have subsequently been reproduced on dust jackets and within the pages of many historical accounts of the town. However, these scenes represent only a very small proportion of Flower's artistic output. This article considers the historical significance of Flower's lesser known topographical works for Leicester and Leicestershire, based on recent work on cataloguing the collection of over 200 sketches and watercolours by Flower held at the Record Office for Leicestershire, Leicester and Rutland, alongside other public collections of his artwork.

Flower was a prolific artist who produced many hundreds of pictures during a career which spanned half a century, the published volume appearing relatively early in that period. It is impossible to estimate his total output, nor to arrive at anything like a comprehensive catalogue of his work, especially as many of Flower's pictures are in private hands and others no doubt have been lost. (2) There are, however, a significant number of his works in public ownership in his native county of Leicestershire. Leicester City Council's Museums Service has approximately 87 of his works, including 26 watercolours. In addition to which they hold some 37 original lithographic prints and a small number of reproductions. Leicestershire County Council's Museum Service has 26 original illustrations by Flower, these being mainly pencil sketches and one watercolour, whilst the Record Office for Leicestershire, Leicester and Rutland (ROLLR) has the largest collection: over 200 topographical pictures, almost all depicting Leicester or Leicestershire scenes. These are mainly pencil sketches and pencil and wash drawings, but include 23 watercolours. (3) J.D. Bennett has provided information on a further collection of 97 topographical pictures offered for sale by a Nottingham art dealer in the late 1960s which included a number of Continental scenes, possibly made during a tour with the artist Samuel Prout. (4) The current whereabouts of this collection is not known. Flower also produced a series of illustrations for a proposed *History of Staffordshire* by J.M. Mathew, F.S.A., that was never published. Some 50 of these drawings have survived and are now in the William Salt Library, Stafford. (5) Peterborough Museum, the Bodleian Library and Cardiff Central Library also have drawings by Flower.

John Flower was primarily a topographical and landscape artist though he also produced some portraits, and there are a small number of still-life pictures in the local collections. He also did some 'hack work' including copies of well-known paintings. (6) During the early part of his career Flower worked mainly in Leicester and Leicestershire but later made sketching tours in the surrounding counties and further afield. The City Museum collection includes pictures of scenes in Warwickshire, Derbyshire, Gloucestershire, Kent, Middlesex, Yorkshire, Westmorland, North and South Wales and the Isle of Man, in addition to a number of Continental locations. The ROLLR collection includes scenes from Oakham, Rutland; near Nuneaton, Warwickshire; at Normanton on Soar, Nottinghamshire and at North Lew, Devon. Flower continued to sketch and paint aspects of his native town and county throughout his life and his last known works are of Leicestershire subjects.



John Flower, Houses near Turret Gateway, Leicester.
(Reproduced by permission of ROLLR.)

The ROLLR collection consists of 219 studies bound in two large volumes. Several of these have sketches on the reverse and in total there are some 233 individual illustrations. Though the vast majority are attributable to John Flower, at least seven are the work of his daughter Elizabeth Flower (1816-1902), an accomplished topographical artist in her own right. There are five more pictures by her in the City Museum collection and another is noted in the collection offered for sale by the Nottingham dealer in the 1960s. Several pictures from the Record Office collection are reproduced in *Leicester: A Pictorial History*, including a fine unsigned watercolour of Leicester Castle from the west bank of the Soar, which Malcolm Elliott attributes to Elizabeth Flower. (7) She illustrated a similar range of subject matter to her father and sometimes accompanied him on sketching tours. It is possible that other pictures in the Record Office collection are by her. A further seven pencil drawings in the collection are the work of another artist, produced much later, in July and August of 1892. These are initialled 'C.K.' and one is signed 'C. Kellet'. This was probably Cornelius William Kellet who enrolled at the Leicester School of Art in 1888 at the age of 15 and may be one and the same person as Cornelius William Kellett, buried in Coventry in 1914. (8) Subject matter consists of early buildings, including a number of churches, mainly in the villages around Leicester. (9)

The circumstances surrounding the acquisition of the collection now housed at the ROLLR and previously part of the Local Studies Collection held at the Central Reference Library in Bishop Street, Leicester are unclear. It is possible that these illustrations were purchased in the early 1930s when the Library was actively expanding its picture collection; more than 700 additions to the collection were made in 1932-3 and almost 600 the following year. (10)

Of the illustrations in the collection by John Flower, approximately half are dated, the earliest being a sketch of the gatehouse at Kirby Muxloe castle made in 1813, when Flower was twenty years old. The last is a detailed sketch at Foston church, dated October 1860, just over a year before his death on 29 November 1861. Spanning almost fifty years this collection demonstrates the range of Flower's topographical work in Leicester and Leicestershire.

As would be expected, there are various illustrations of early buildings in Leicester, including versions of some of the published lithographs. Rapid sketches, one or two evidently made during demolition, have a particular immediacy. Of note is a pencil sketch entitled *Houses near Turret Gateway* showing a series of jettied timber-framed buildings. These were presumably located on the west side of Castle View on the site subsequently occupied by the Old Castle Inn, a nineteenth century public house also since demolished.

Another pencil sketch with the title *Town Hall Lane* shows a jettied structure, identifiable from the adjacent inn sign as the building that stood above a twelfth century undercroft in what is now Guildhall Lane. (11) This building was demolished in 1861 exposing the undercroft, which was photographed at that time by Mr J. Weatherhead the Museum Curator. This was revealed again in 2003 during excavations in advance of construction of the new BBC Radio Leicester building. (12) The undercroft had first come to John Flower's attention in 1844 when sketching some Norman arches in the belfry of St Martin's church; the sexton was reminded of similar arches in the cellar of his own house nearby. Flower visited him that evening, inspected the cellar and made a sketch. The existence of the undercroft was reported to the Royal Archaeological Institute in the same year and Flower's sketch exhibited at a meeting of the committee. (13)



John Flower, *Town Hall Lane*, Leicester. (Reproduced by permission of ROLLR.)

In the Leicestershire Museums collection there is a fine pencil sketch of an unidentified street scene depicting a late medieval jettied building with arched doorway. The sign on an adjacent building reads 'Sharp Builder Garden Chair Maker'. *White's Directory* for 1846 lists a John Sharp Builder and Rustic Chair Maker on Highcross Street, Leicester. Subsequent directories identify him variously as a builder, carpenter and joiner, locating his premises on the west side of Highcross Street, between Friars Causeway and All Saints Open. The 1855 *Post Office Directory of Leicestershire and Rutland* pinpoints the location, listing Sharp's address as 134 Highcross Street, Leicester. In the illustration there is a double-pile, wide-frontage house to the left of the jettied building and beyond that a boundary wall with gate and trees behind. This precise arrangement is shown on the first edition Ordnance Survey 1:500 map sheet XXX1.10.24 published in 1887. Although the jettied building had evidently been demolished by then, and replaced by a covered carriageway giving access to a pair of properties erected at the back of the plot, its location is readily identifiable. Interestingly there is a rough sketch in the ROLLR collection entitled *Sketch of an Old House in High X Street taken down August 29 1848* showing the first floor and roof structure of a similar looking building, made during demolition, which may in fact be the same building.

The population of Leicester increased rapidly in the nineteenth century, with new factories and acres of workers' housing spreading out over the former open fields (14). Pictures of various agricultural and other buildings on the outskirts of Leicester, including *Barn in the Spa Front Field Humberstone Road*, *Sketch of a Summer House on the Freemans Common* and *Barn on the Occupation Road* (now University Road), illustrate Flower was aware of the changing character of Leicester's hinterland and a concern for recording the remaining agricultural buildings and rural landscape of the area immediately outside the town before these vanished entirely.

A series of pictures illustrating the rural character of those villages and farms on the outskirts of Leicester, already feeling the pressure of urban expansion by the middle of the nineteenth century, and subsequently engulfed by the town, may be viewed in a similar light.

A linked theme is an enduring interest in recording examples of impermanent architecture – short-lived, functional structures including sheds, fences, signposts, hayricks and the like, all of which have now vanished. Of these the sketch of a small plank-built shed at Syston, serving as a railway office, and the *Sketch of a Screen [toilet] on the Railway*, dated 1833, demonstrate an oblique interest in contemporary subject matter. In fact Flower recorded various contemporary buildings. Of the many churches he

illustrated, for example, St George's, Swannington was only seven years old when he sketched this in 1832. (15)

Pictures of many of Leicestershire's gentry houses, both ancient and more 'modern', can be found in all three of the major Leicestershire public collections of Flower's work. (16) No doubt some of these were privately commissioned by the house owners, as would have been some of the numerous illustrations of substantial rectories and other large houses. Examples include the pencil and wash drawing of the *Old Manor House at Enderby September 23rd 1837*, a fine example of a surviving building with medieval origins. There are three different sketched views of Belvoir Castle in the Record Office collection, one of which was included in the published volume of lithographs. These show the house following the major remodelling begun in 1801 by James Wyatt and completed by the Rev. Sir John Thoroton after Wyatt's death in 1813 and a serious fire in 1816. The sketches are undated but must have been made in or before 1826. According to Pevsner work on the house was not finally completed until c.1830. (17)

These collected illustrations provide some indication of how Flower approached this type of work. Preliminary field sketches, often gridded, include copious notes on subject matter and lighting. From these he produced more refined and often quite exquisite pencil and wash drawings, though still with notes and detail sketches suggesting that they were not the finished product. In some instances the final illustrations were 'drawn on stone' by Flower and lithographic prints made. In other cases the final version may have been a watercolour, which the client received, with Flower retaining the preliminary drawings. (18) In any event the surviving preparatory illustrations provide a valuable record of the appearance of a number of substantial houses in the county in the first half of the nineteenth century, all the more so where those houses have subsequently been altered or demolished. For example, Danet's Hall and Westcotes, on the outskirts of Leicester, Cadeby Hall, Hinckley Hall, Stoughton Grange and Swithland Hall have all now gone. The two illustrations of Stoughton Grange show this in its Gothic form, following the alterations made by Anthony Keck around 1754, but before the substantial remodelling of 1882-3; the house was subsequently demolished in 1925-6. Similarly, two illustrations of Barkby Hall show this before it was considerably reduced in size in 1870 (though whether before or after the fire in 1847 is uncertain at this stage). (19) Field sketches of Swithland Hall show the building that was burnt down in 1822; the existing Swithland Hall, completed in 1852, was built on a new site. A lithograph of the earlier hall, based on the field sketches, was included in the 1972 reprint of *Views of Ancient Buildings in the Town and County of Leicester*. (20)



John Flower, Barn in the Spa Front Field, Humberstone Road, Leicester, July 1836. (Reproduced by permission of ROLLR.)



John Flower, Sketch of a signpost. (Reproduced by permission of ROLLR.)



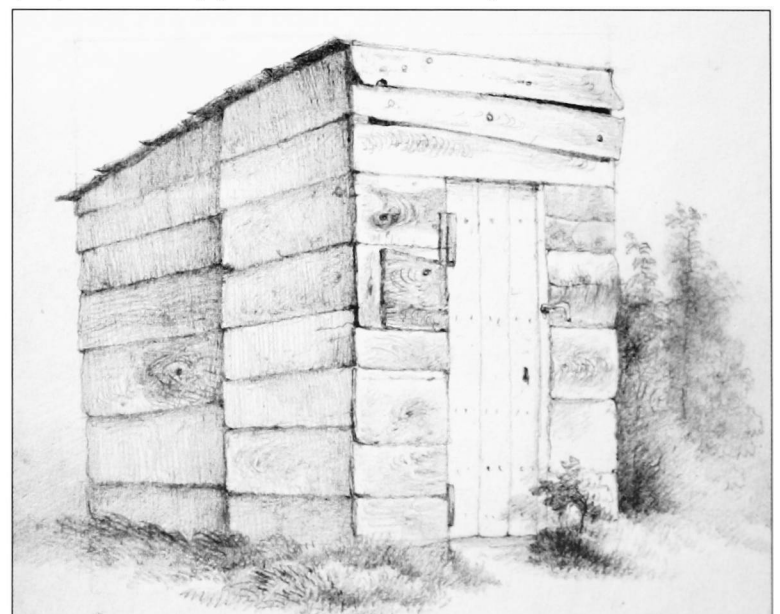
John Flower, Shed at Syston, serving as a railway office. (Reproduced by permission of ROLLR.)



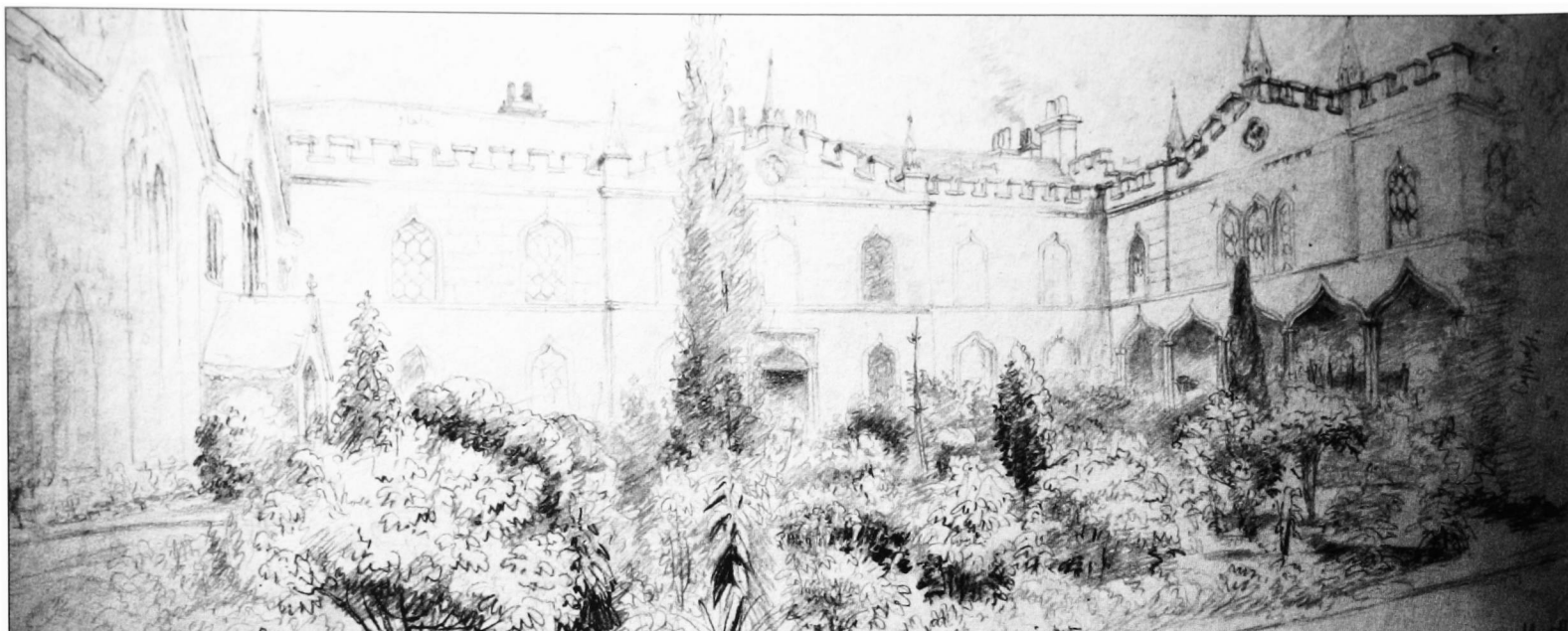
John Flower, Sketch of a farm building, September 1838. (Reproduced by permission of ROLLR.)



John Flower, Hayrick at Quorndon. (Reproduced by permission of ROLLR.)



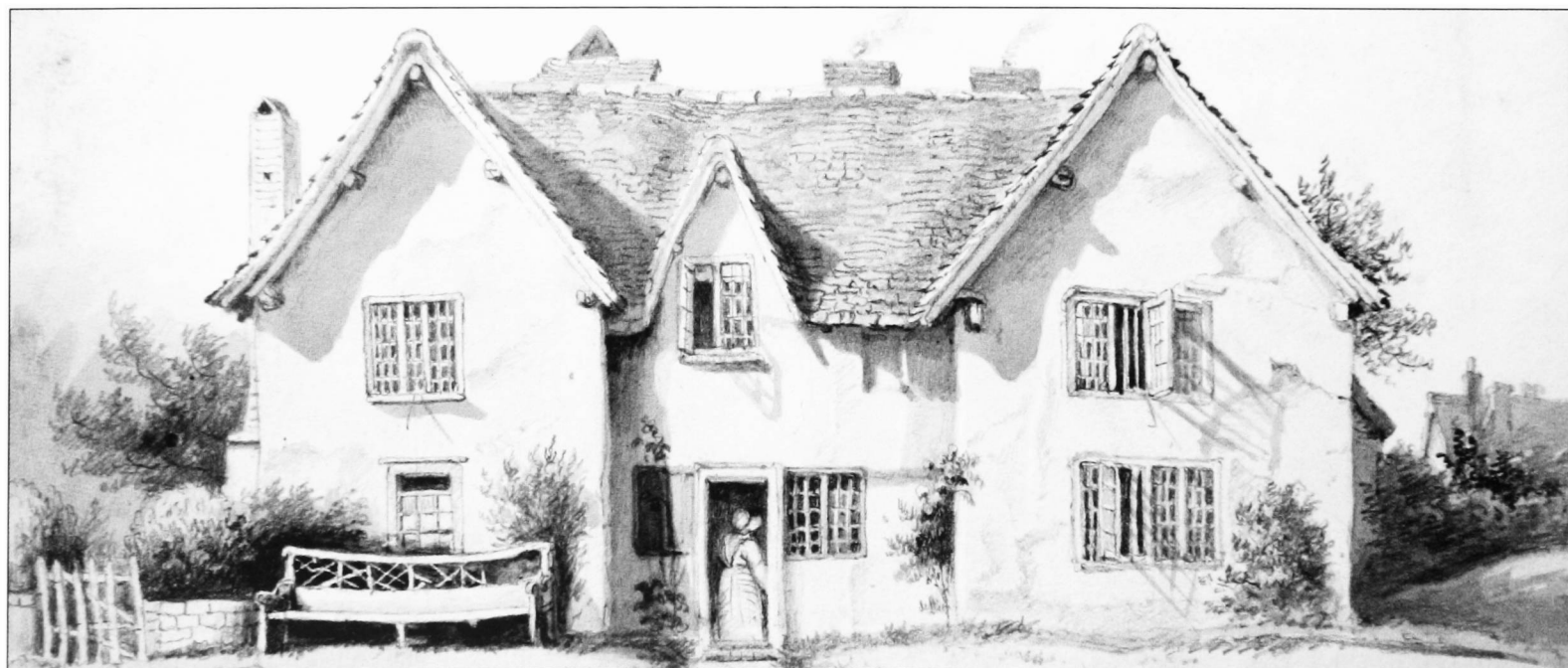
John Flower, Sketch of a Summer House on the Freemans Common, Leicester. (Reproduced by permission of ROLLR.)



John Flower, Stoughton Grange before the remodelling of 1882-3. (Reproduced by permission of ROLLR.)



John Flower, Annotated sketch of Carlton Hall near Kibworth. (Reproduced by permission of ROLLR.)



John Flower, the Old Manor House at Enderby, September 1837. (Reproduced by permission of ROLLR.)

The published volume of *Views...* was originally issued in parts to subscribers, as indicated by an advertisement in the *Leicester Journal* for 18th March 1825. (21) On the reverse of one picture in the ROLLR collection and another in the Leicestershire Museum collection are notes in Flower's hand working out the order of publication. Where he changed his mind titles are crossed through and replaced by others. Significantly, these lists include reference to pictures that are otherwise unknown, of Lord's Place and St Margaret's church, Leicester. Quenby Hall is also mentioned with the note 'I am to sketch', though whether this sketch was ever made is not known. (22)

There are many illustrations of significant historical monuments in the three public collections, including, for example, pictures of Leicester Castle and the Newarke, Leicester Abbey and Cavendish House, and the ruins at Kirby Muxloe, Ashby de la Zouch, Bradgate, Ulverscroft and Grace Dieu. Flower returned many times to sketch some of these subjects; there are more than a dozen views at Leicester Abbey in the ROLLR collection alone, ranging in date from the 1820s to the 1850s. Flower evidently recognised the historical significance of some of his own work, for example, a pencil sketch of St John's stone, a substantial monolith of presumed prehistoric date which stood in a field near Abbey Lane to the north of the town. Having sketched this in 1815 (on the reverse of another picture), he noted in 1857 that 'this original sketch is now valuable'. By that date the stone had been broken up to repair roads. Another version of this illustration was included in William Kelly's *Royal Progresses* published in 1884. (23) Pictures of a Roman column dug up in Leicester in 1850 and an Anglo-Saxon brooch found at Ingarsby, in addition to the published views of the Jewry Wall and the Roman milestone at Belgrave, further illustrate his interest in 'antiquarian study'. (24)

Flower was also a drawing master – he taught drawing at Ratcliffe College and at a school in Ullesthorpe. (25) Some of the latest illustrations in the ROLLR collection were made with his pupils, indicating that he continued to work as a drawing master almost until the end of his life. There are various detail sketches made 'with pupils', at Quorndon in 1842, at Broughton Astley in 1844 ('with Narboro' pupils') and at Ullesthorpe in 1849 and 1859, for example. There are also some collaborative pieces, including *Buttress at Foston Ch Sketched by M Payton shaded by J.F. October 1860*. A series of annotated technical drawings illustrating the rules of perspective presumably represent teaching aids; there is another similar drawing in the City Museum collection entitled *Three Studies in Perspective for Buildings*.

John Flower's enduring legacy is the visual record he created of Leicester and Leicestershire in the early part of the nineteenth century. (26) It is surprising then that the

illustrations in the ROLLR collection are not more widely known. This may be due in part to the fact that so few of Flower's pictures were published in his own lifetime, when volumes of topographical views were popular. (27)

It is hoped in due course to compile and publish as full a list as possible of the known works of both John Flower and Elizabeth Flower. To this end members are invited to provide (in strictest confidence) details of any original pictures in private ownership (though not reproductions of illustrations from the published volume of lithographs, very many of which are in circulation). It would also be useful to trace the collection sold by the Nottingham dealer in 1968 and to confirm the current whereabouts of pictures that were in the possession of the executors of Mrs J. Broughton, The Wilderness, Barkby Thorpe, in the 1960s, as recorded in J.D. Bennett's *Transactions* article. Probably the most fitting tribute to John Flower 'The Leicester Artist' would be an exhibition of his work in his native town, arranged perhaps to coincide with the 150th anniversary of his death in 2011.

Notes and References:

1. *Views of Ancient Buildings in the Town and County of Leicester*, Drawn on Stone by John Flower, printed Leicester, 1826. For an account of the life and work of the artist see the articles by J.D. Bennett 'John Flower 1793-1861' in *Transactions of the Leicestershire Archaeological and Historical Society* Vol. XLII (1966-7), p.76-81 and 'The Leicester Artist' in *Leicestershire Historian* Vol. 1, no. 3 (1968), p.62-65. A portrait of John Flower painted in 1841 hangs in the Newarke Houses Museum.
2. J.D. Bennett produced a representative list of 65 topographical pictures by John Flower as an appendix to his 1966-7 *Transactions* article; many more illustrations have come to light since that time.
3. *John Flower Pencil Sketches and Water Colours (Leicestershire)*. ROLLR: L914.2. The collection has recently been catalogued prompting this assessment of Flower's topographical work in Leicester and Leicestershire.
4. Information contained in a copy of the catalogue of Ian H. R. Cowley 233 Mansfield Road, Nottingham, England, dated 1968.
5. A.C. Sewter, 'Leicestershire Artists' in *Victoria County History of Leicester* Vol. III (1955), p.234.
6. J.D. Bennett, 1966-7. See Ref. 1, p.78; 1968. See ref. 1, p.62.
7. Malcolm Elliott, *Leicester A Pictorial History*, (Chichester: Phillimore, 1999), p.138.
8. Information on the Leicester School of Art kindly supplied by Linda Butt. Grant of Burial recorded in the *Minutes of Coventry City Council* for 1914.
9. Sketches by Cornelius Kellert in the Record Office collection: St Mary de Castro church, Leicester 2.7.92; packhorse bridge, Aylestone 23.7.92; St Peter's church,

Braunstone 28.7.92; timber-framed cottage, Braunstone 28.7.92; St Denys' church tower, Evington 13.8.92; cottages on Leicester Lane, Evington 13.8.92; St Mary's church, Humberstone 21.7.92.

10. *City of Leicester Municipal Libraries Fifty-fourth Report to the City Council 1st April, 1932 to 31st March, 1933*. Leicester: C.H. Gee & Co.; *City of Leicester Municipal Libraries Fifty-fifth Report to the City Council 1st April, 1933 to 31st March, 1934*. Leicester: W. Thornley & Son, Bowling Green Street.

11. The sign of the Crown and Thistle, on the adjacent building to the east, is also shown in Flower's published view of *The Town Hall, Leicester* with the jettied building just visible beyond it. The precise location is confirmed with reference to the notebooks of the early nineteenth century mapmaker Robert Unicume held at the Record Office for Leicestershire, Leicester and Rutland. Tony Gnanaratnam of ULAS has reconstructed elements of Unicume's survey at a larger scale from his original measurements, overlaying this on to first edition Ordnance Survey maps.

12. Roger Kipling, '9 St Nicholas Place (SK 5840 0448)' in *TLAHS* 78 (2004), p.151-6.

13. *Archaeological Journal* Vol. 1 (1844), p.390-1.

14. R.H. Evans, 'The expansion of Leicester in the nineteenth century' in A.E. Brown (ed.), *The Growth of Leicester*, (Leicester University Press, 1970).

15. Bernard Daws *A Brief History of St George's Church, Swannington* (1993). Swannington Heritage Trust. There are a number of illustrations of unidentified churches in the County Museum Service collection, all thought to be in Leicestershire; it is hoped to confirm the identity of at least some of these in due course.

16. Including: Aylestone Hall, Baggrave Hall, Barkby Hall, Belvoir Castle, Bradgate House, Braunstone Hall, Carlton Curlieu Hall, Cadeby Hall, Cavendish House, Danets Hall, Enderby Hall, Groby Old Hall, Hinckley Hall, Ingarsby Old Hall, Launde Abbey, Lowesby Hall, Narborough Hall, Scraftoft Hall, Stoughton Grange, Swithland Hall, Thurcaston Hall and Westcotes Hall.

17. N. Pevsner, rev. E. Williamson, *The Buildings of England: Leicestershire and Rutland*, 2nd ed. (London: Penguin Books, 1992), p.95-101.

18. Further research is planned in this area; it is possible that details of commissions survive in collections of family or estate papers associated with some of the gentry houses that Flower illustrated.

19. Pevsner and Williamson, 1992. See Ref. 17, p.398 (Stoughton Grange); p.90 (Barkby Hall).

20. Pevsner and Williamson, 1992. See Ref. 17, p.402. The 1972 facsimile edition of *Views of Ancient Buildings in the Town and County of Leicester* produced by DeElarge, High Street, Syston also includes biographical notes on John Flower by J.D. Bennett.

21. 'Mr Flower, Artist, Leicester, Proposes to Publish by Subscription, Twenty Lithographic Views of Castles,

Abbeys, and Ancient Buildings, in the County and Town of Leicester. The Work to consist of Four Parts, each containing Five Views, on fine paper, Imperial Quarto. The price of each part to Subscribers Six Shillings...' *Leicester Journal*, 18th March, 1825.

22. Lord's Place fronted the modern High Street and was the Leicester residence of Henry, third Earl of Huntingdon, the borough's patron in the late 16th century. Paul Courtney 'Lord's Place, Leicester: an Urban Aristocratic House of the Sixteenth Century' in *TLAHS* 74 (2000), p.37-58.

23. William Kelly, *Royal progresses and visits to Leicester, from the reputed foundations of the city by King Leir, B.C. 844 to the present time* (1844). Leicester: Samuel Clark. Illustration opposite p.17 entitled 'St John's Stone as it appeared in 1815, from an original drawing by J. Flower' The precise location of this monolith is marked on the first edition Ordnance Survey map.

24. Flower's obituary notice in the *Leicester Chronicle* on 7th December 1861 refers to his 'love of gothic architecture, and of antiquarian study, and a taste for collecting objects of vertu...' cited in J.D. Bennett 1996-7. See Ref. 1, p.78.

25. A.C. Sewter, 1955. See Ref. 5, p.234; J.D. Bennett 1966-7. See Ref. 1, p.76,78.

26. A.C. Sewter, 1955. See Ref. 5, p.234; J.D. Bennett 1966-7. See Ref. 1, p.78.

27. See biographical notes by J.D. Bennett in the 1972 reprint of *Views of Ancient Buildings in the Town and County of Leicester*. See Ref. 20.

Acknowledgements:

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